



AFTER

Some 2.5 million men served in the Union army in the course of the Civil War. Of these, around 360,000 died in battle or of hardship and disease.

DEMOBILIZATION

No thought was given during the war to the problem of **returning men to civilian life**. Soldiers whose terms of service ended and who chose not to reenlist simply returned to their homes. At the war's end public opinion demanded swift demobilization. **Union soldiers were gathered in camps** for discharge, but many deserted before the slow and tedious mustering out process was complete.

VETERANS' PENSIONS'

By 1865, a **system of pensions** had been put in place **for disabled veterans and for the widows and orphans** of Union soldiers who had died in the war. In 1904, pensions were in effect extended to **all surviving Civil War veterans** in their old age. There were still individuals drawing Civil War pensions in the 1950s.

A CONTINUING ROLE

Rapidly depleted, the U.S. Army nonetheless was burdened with important tasks after the Civil War. **The South** came under **military rule** during the **Reconstruction period** (see [Building Black communities](#)), while the **Plains Indian Wars** kept the army actively employed into the 1880s, many Civil War veterans seeing action against the American Indians.